Androcles and the LION

There once lived a slave whose name was Androcles. His Roman master was very cruel and often beat him with a big stick. At last the poor slave could stand it no longer and he made up his mind to run away.

"I will leave this dreadful place, and go away into the country," he said to himself. "There I will be free, and my cruel master will not be able to find me."

Androcles knew that he would need to be very careful. If the soldiers caught him trying to escape, they would put him in prison. The slave waited until it was dark, and then slipped quietly out of the house. He made his way very carefully out of the town without being seen by any of the soldiers.

When he reached the country, Androcles ran as fast as he could. On and on he went until he came to a large forest.

The slave walked for many hours through the woods. His clothes were torn by the thorny branches of the trees, and he was very hungry.

Suddenly he saw a large cave in the side of a hill.

"What a good hiding place!" he cried. "No one will find me here!"

Androcles entered the cave and soon found a cosy spot to rest. He was so tired and weary, that in a few minutes he was fast asleep.

The runaway slave had not slept very long, when he was wakened by a loud roar. There, at the mouth of the cave and coming towards him, was a huge lion. To his surprise, the beast did not spring at him, but limped slowly to his side. The animal held up one of its front paws and moaned sadly, as if it was in need of help.

Very bravely, Androcles took hold of the paw and looked at it. At once he saw the cause of all the trouble.

A large sharp thorn had stuck in the animal's foot, and the creature was suffering great pain. As gently as he could, the slave pulled out the thorn.

When the thorn was out, the lion was very pleased. The animal wagged its tail, purred like a big cat, and licked the hands of the man who had been so kind.

For three years, Androcles and the lion shared the same home. Every day, the lion went out hunting and brought back food. At night, the slave slept in a cosy bed at the back of the cave. The lion lay near the mouth of the cave, so that Androcles would come to no harm.

One day, Androcles was walking in the forest, when he was captured by some Roman soldiers, who were hunting wild animals.

Alas, they told him that he would be put to death, and that he would be torn to pieces by a lion.

On the day that he was to die, many people went to the great circus to watch the terrible sight. The emperor was there, and he was seated on a high throne. When all was ready, Androcles was left alone in the middle of the circus.

Soon a loud roar was heard, as a huge hungry lion was let loose. The animal, with red angry eyes and wide-open jaws, bounded swiftly towards the lonely slave in the middle of the circus. Everyone expected it to spring upon the man and crush him with a mighty blow of its paw.

Suddenly, when only a few feet away from poor Androcles, it stopped and sniffed the air. The people were silent. They had never seen anything like this before.

The lion went slowly forward, wagged its tail, and rubbed its head against him, just like a pet cat at home. Androcles knew at once that it was his old friend who had lived with him in the cave.

The people were amazed at the strange sight and the emperor sent for Androcles. When the slave told him the wonderful story, the king was so pleased that he set him free and gave him the lion as a present.

For many years Androcles kept the lion as a pet, and they were always together. Everyone knew their story, and smiled or waved as they passed. The lion followed his master everywhere he went, and at night the faithful animal slept outside his door.

(adapted)

Comprehension skills

1 During what part of the day does the slave make his escape?
  a) afternoon b) evening c) night
2 How were the slave's clothes torn?
3 Why didn't it take very long for the slave to fall asleep?
4 What noise awoke the slave?
5 What word describes how the lion moved towards the slave?
6 Why was the lion sad?
7 How did the lion react when the thorn was removed?
8 How long did Androcles live with the lion in the cave?
  a) 3 days b) 3 months c) 3 years
9 What did the lion do during the day?
10 Who had gathered in the great circus?
11 How do you think the lion recognised that the slave in the circus was Androcles?
12 How did the people react to what happened?

Critical literacy

Thinking about the story

1 Androcles was brave. He was brave to escape from his master. He was brave to take the thorn from the lion's paw and he was brave when he was sent to the great circus. Do you think it is important to be brave? Can you think of a time when you have had to be brave? Write about bravery. You may include a picture if you wish.

Thinking beyond the story

2 Lions are not usually kept as pets. Use books or the internet to do some research about lions and write a few sentences about them. Have an adult help you if you use the internet.